



*BVR Mohan Reddy with family*

electronics data processing. My learning did not end after college. I joined MICO (Motor Industries Company Ltd, MICO Bosch, and now Robert Bosch) as a systems analyst. My job was all about systems design and programming!” he exclaims.

Terming it the stone age of computers, Mohan narrates how he started learning how to program in Autocoder and everything about computers. “From diesel engines, I had dived into computer software, working day and night. It was amazing learning about leadership, working in teams, and adapting to different work environments,” he says.

With significant experience learning about operations and computer systems, Mohan made his next jump into sales. His decisions were questioned, but Mohan was not one to be deterred by what people would say. “I had handled operations and systems, and now I wanted to handle sales. I was determined to cultivate a rich experience in every aspect of business. I convinced Shiv Nadar, from Hindustan Computers Limited (HCL), that I would bring my best to his team, and he recruited me as an

area sales manager. I worked for him for three years, learning the ropes of sales as an introvert. I was great at one-on-one conversations, but convincing a large group of people was a totally new challenge. Eventually, I became the best salesman and then the best national sales manager for HCL,” he reminisces.

“After working for two and half years and gaining enough knowledge about sales operations, I decided it was time to think about my entrepreneurial journey.”

While funds ran low, Mohan’s aspirations were skyrocketing. “In the late 1970s, during the microprocessor revolution, private companies like DCM, HCL, ORG, and the public sector company ECIL began manufacturing microprocessor-based and mini computers. By the early 1980s, I believed India could become a significant computer market and wanted to become an entrepreneur by manufacturing PCs,” he says.

In 1982, with insufficient money and no proper technology, went to get a licence from the government of India to manufacture computers. The free market did not exist, and there

were a million roadblocks to procuring licences. But who can deter the determined? Then, Mohan came across an alternative: the Tata Group was investing in a technology owned by Dr Raj Reddy, a researcher based out of Carnegie Mellon University, and was looking for a founder-CEO. “It seemed like a promising opportunity for me,” says Mohan.

OMC was a systems integration company that built CPU boxes in India and integrated them with imported peripherals. The systems were optionally loaded with CAD/CAM software. The product targeted the nascent CAD/CAM market. But just being a CEO wasn’t enough. Mohan knew his experience and skill set deserved more, so he asked for the managing director (MD) position as well. “Initially, they refused because it was a board position, but I stuck to my statement and let them know that they wouldn’t have a CEO if they refused,” he says.

Recognising his leadership skills, the Tata Group agreed to his demands, and he became the first CEO-MD in the company’s history at the age of 30. “Becoming managing director of a Tata Group company was unprecedented. I dedicated nearly a decade to this role, culminating as I approached my fortieth birthday. It was then when I decided to re-ignite the fire for a dream I had been harbouring since 1974,” he narrates.

At the helm of the CAD/CAM revolution in India, Mohan oversaw the setup of an OMC electronics manufacturing plant in Hyderabad equipped with PCB component stuffing machines, wave soldering machines, and testing equipment. “We broadened our product range significantly by introducing a PC line with CAD software for low-end drafting solutions in large volumes,” he recounts.